Resources & Support

Learn · Support · Advance Awareness
Understanding · Action · Community

📚 OFFICIAL & LOCAL US RESOURCES

- **Infant & Toddler Connection (ITC) (703) 246-7121**: Single point of entry for early intervention, ages 0–3. Anyone can refer; services regardless of ability to pay. No SSN needed to make a referral.
- **Child Find (FCPS) 571-423-4121**: Free developmental screening, ages 20 months–5 years (Fairfax County / City residents); child must turn 2 by Sept 30. Falls Church City has its own Child Find.
- **CDC "Learn the Signs. Act Early"**: Free milestone checklists (materials in Chinese). Checklists do not replace formal screening.
- **Autism Speaks 100-Day Kit**: Practical first-100-days toolkit after a diagnosis (children 4 and under; Chinese available).
- 📞 **ASNV · asnv.org** Education programs, support groups, and community resources

📬 CONTACT & PRESENTATIONS

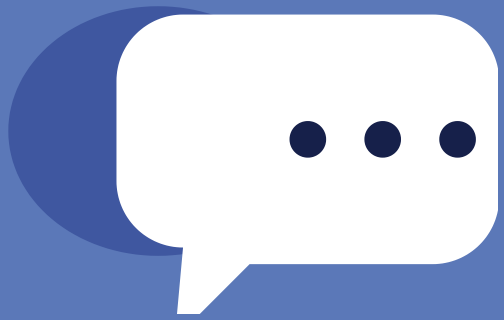
- Email: ezhengva@gmail.com
- Website: emmaz-sv.github.io/early-autism-awareness

- Free bilingual presentations for schools, clinics, and community groups

Scan for bilingual site
扫码访问双语网站
emmaz-sv.github.io/early-autism-awareness

© 2026 Emma Zheng · All educational materials free to distribute
Sources: CDC, NIH, FCPS Child Find, Fairfax ITC

Early Autism Awareness Project



Our Mission

Emma Zheng · Early Autism Awareness Project

Empowering Chinese-speaking immigrant families with early autism awareness, helping parents recognize early warning signs, and guiding them to accessible local screening and intervention services.

🧠 Early Brain Growth (Ages 0–5)

By about age 3, a child's brain is roughly 80% of adult size; by about age 5, roughly 90%. Earlier identification and support are generally associated with better long-term communication, social, and adaptive outcomes.

Project Footprint: Chinese-speaking families with children ages 0–5 across the DMV · Bilingual community education · Free downloadable resources

Early Signs & Red Flags

CDC Milestones (Selected Ages, 0–5 Years)

👀 **Limited Eye Contact**

👆 **No Pointing to Show**

💬 **Delayed Speech**

🔁 **Repetitive Behaviors**

🧸 **No Pretend Play**

📢 **Sensory Sensitivities**

⚠️ **"Golden Rule" (Any Age):** Any regression or loss of speech, babbling, eye contact, gestures, or social skills at any age: contact your pediatrician promptly. Do not wait for the next well-child visit.

🧩 SOCIAL, PLAY & COMMUNICATION (CDC 2022)

By ~9 Months: Does not respond to name

12 Months: No babbling · Not waving bye-bye · Does not play peek-a-boo

15 Months: Not pointing to ask · Does not bring/show toys to share excitement

16–18 Months: No single words · Not pointing to show by 18 months

By ~30 Months: Little or no pretend play

Behavioral Patterns: Hand-flapping, rocking, spinning · Extreme distress at everyday sounds or lights

Note: Milestone ages follow CDC 2022 revised checklists; children develop at different rates. Checklists do not replace formal screening. If concerned, talk to your pediatrician.



🧩 Multidimensional Spectrum Wheel

Autism is a broad spectrum where developmental domains vary independently. Each child forms a unique profile, highlighting strengths while guiding tailored support.

📋 4 STEPS TO SEEK SUPPORT

1. **Observe & Track:** Note specific concerns with milestone checklists. Checklists do not replace formal screening.
2. **Talk to Your Pediatrician:** Ask for an M-CHAT-R/F screen (and developmental screening). You can request extra screening anytime if concerned.
3. **Comprehensive Assessment:** Moderate/high risk prompts referral for full evaluation.
4. **Start Early Intervention:** Contact Fairfax ITC (703) 246-7121 (ages 0–3) or FCPS Child Find 571-423-4121 (20 months–5 years). A suspected delay is enough to refer; no formal diagnosis needed, and no SSN needed to make a referral.

❓ MISCONCEPTIONS & CLINICAL FACTS

MYTH

"Children who can speak cannot have autism."

FACT

Autism is a broad spectrum. Many autistic children speak fluently but need support with social reciprocity, nonverbal cues, or sensory regulation.

MYTH

"The child is young; let us wait and see if they outgrow it."

FACT

Earlier support is generally associated with better outcomes. Waiting can delay help during a period of rapid brain growth. If you are concerned, contact your pediatrician or ITC promptly.

MYTH

"Autism is caused by cold parenting or vaccines."

FACT

Autism is an innate neurodevelopmental difference. Decades of research refute links to parenting styles or vaccines.

Autism is an innate neurodevelopmental difference, unrelated to parenting or vaccines. For ages 0–5, earlier identification and support are generally linked with better long-term outcomes.